

**GHOST****What is GHOST?**

GHOST is the new OS from Google. It has been released to select Gmail users in the United States by special invitation, since the 'Rest Of The World' is not important to Google. (Just kidding. Google wants to take over the world, even the part of the world outside the United States.)

When will GHOST be available?

It's already available in the US. As for when it will be available in India, how are we supposed to know? We suppose it depends on when real "broadband" comes to India.

Why the silly name?

You can pronounce it as either "gee-host," or just "ghost." It's not a silly name, anyway: the word "GHOST" is an acronym for "Google Has an Operating System, Ta-daa!"

How does GHOST work?

Like everything Google, GHOST is very easy to use. It's something like grid computing. All you need is a ridiculously fast (by Indian standards) broadband connection. All your files, details of all your interactions with the system, and so on, will be stored on Google's servers. You just start a GHOST session and compute what you like, when you like. Google even has plans to host free pornography on its servers.

Where will GHOST be used?

Dumb question. It will, obviously, be used all over the world, including in the Democratic Republic of Congo, which, for the geographically challenged, is in South America.

Who is reading this?

If you've read thus far and gotten excited, you're obviously the butt of many practical jokes! Going by guesses on the Web, a Google OS is not expected anytime this year. It could be next year, though. Stay tuned to this space, and you might see something interesting next year. To ensure that you are the first to know, we suggest that you get yourself a *Digit* subscription. Oh and by the way, "Nyaaah nya nyaaaaaah nyaaa nyaaaaaahh, April Fool!"

example, if a corporate IT buyer needs their workers connected, a BlackBerry is probably a better option.

BlackBerry, cell phone, iPod, laptop, all rolled into one—and then shrunk. Is this a different kind of MFD? Unfortunately, no. It doesn't do any of those functions properly—it's not small enough, not large enough, not specialised enough. We're hard pressed to think of what kind of individual would want a UMPC.

"SPREADING CULTURE"

File-sharing Embedded In Swedish Mindset

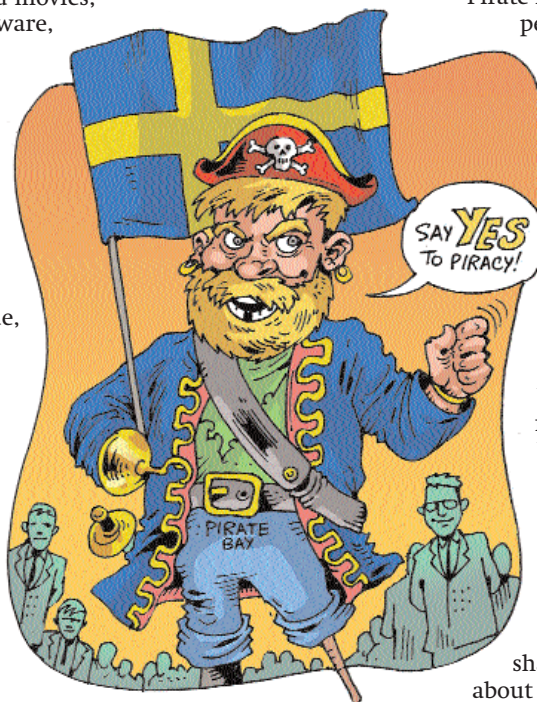
The Pirate Bay (thepiratebay.org) is the world's best-known source for (illegally) traded movies, games, music, software, TV broadcasts, and anything else you might care to add to that list. A BitTorrent client is all one needs to tap into the grid, and much of the world's broadband community is doing it. As an aside, we reported some time ago in this space that Australians prefer to get their dose of American TV shows on time using BitTorrent, instead of waiting for them to be released on TV.

Sweden is file-sharing paradise, and the country is spreading the joy. According to an analysis on *Wired.com*, "All of us who run The Pirate Bay are against the copyright laws and want them to change," said "Brokep," a Pirate Bay operator. "We see it as our

duty to spread culture and media. Technology is just a means to doing that." That's so radical, we don't know if they really mean it, but The Pirate Bay repeatedly insists that that is their agenda.

The site today claims 1 million *unique* visitors a day. The Pirate Bay's legal adviser, law student Mikael Viborg, said the site receives 1,000 to 2,000 HTTP requests per second on each of its four servers.

In Sweden, The Pirate Bay is the flagship of a national file-sharing movement that is generating an intense national debate. The Bay's apparent immunity to threats by content providers and the MPAA is attributed to the structure of the BitTorrent protocol. The site's servers provide only "torrent files," which by themselves contain no copyright data, but only pointers to sources of the



content. Naturally, then, The Pirate Bay's activities are perfectly legal under Swedish law. "Until the law is changed so that it is clear that the trackers are illegal, or until the Swedish Supreme Court rules that current Swedish copyright

law actually outlaws trackers, we'll continue our activities. Relentlessly," Viborg is reported to have proclaimed.

The legality of the trackers is a topic of debate in Sweden. Polls indicate that more than 10 per cent of the population shared files in the last quarter of 2005.

The group that founded the Bay—*Piratbyrå*—is taking to grass-roots activism and political legitimacy. *Piratbyrå* today has 57,000 registered members committed to its belief that file trading is a means of sharing culture and making new art.

Now here's something way out: the Pirate Party has 1,500 members, and has gathered enough signatures to participate in the Swedish general election in September. The government estimates there are 1.2 million file sharers over the age of 18 in Sweden, and the Pirate Party needs only four per cent to get seats in the parliament. If elected, the Pirate Party promises to strengthen Swedish privacy protections, weaken copyright laws, and roll back government surveillance legislation.

Will Sweden become a precedent for other countries? When will the file-sharing-being-legal debate be resolved? Will the MPAA and other such groups formulate new strategies in the war against illegal file-sharing? And what about the current generation—10 years from now, will the broadband-enabled world think of file-sharing as essentially a good thing? Or is all this limited to Sweden with a population of only 10 million? The debates continue, and probably will for a long, long time. ■